Commerce

One-page brief

Priority: 11 of 33 (score 3.3). **FY2026 outlays:** $20B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27. Public data only.

Bottom line

Commerce is a small spender today with two very large programs now paying out: NTIA's $42.45B Broadband Equity, Access and Deployment (BEAD) program, passed through states to internet providers, and the CHIPS manufacturing incentives. Big new money to new or re-formed recipients is the classic setup for fraud, and both programs publish recipient-level data. This is a chance to screen before the money is spent, not after.

Exposure

- $20B in outlays but $52B in budgetary resources in FY2026, reflecting BEAD and CHIPS money not yet spent.
- Broadband subsidy fraud has precedent in the FCC's E-Rate and rural programs (see fcc.pdf): inflated costs, coverage claims that do not match service, and bid rigging.

Public data we can use

- **State BEAD subgrantee selections** (published by each state) and NTIA approvals.
- **FCC National Broadband Map:** provider-reported coverage by location.
- **USAspending** for CHIPS, EDA and NIST awards.
- **SAM.gov** and the FCC's USF data for provider histories.

Detection plays

1. **Coverage claims vs. reality:** BEAD-funded locations already shown as served on the FCC map, or providers claiming coverage they cannot show.
2. **Provider history:** BEAD winners with prior USF enforcement, new entities with no network history, or shared owners across bidders.
3. **Cost outliers:** cost per location far above peers in similar terrain.

First prototype

A BEAD subgrantee screen for two or three states that have published awards, joining FCC map and USF history.

Limits

State award data formats vary; build-out verification needs field data.

Who to take it to

NTIA Office of Internet Connectivity and Growth, Commerce OIG, and state broadband offices.

Sources

- NTIA BEAD program
- FCC National Broadband Map
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)